

Brown

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hits, two runs, a 2-1 loss; April 16, seven innings, two hits, no runs, a win; April 21, seven innings, six hits, no earned runs, a loss; April 26, 7 $\frac{2}{3}$ innings, eight hits, four earned runs, a win; May 1, nine innings, nine hits, two earned runs, a win; May 7, six innings (double-header game), four hits, two earned runs, a loss; May 12 (a relapse), 3 $\frac{2}{3}$ innings, 10 hits, six earned runs, a loss; May 18, nine innings, 11 hits, a 7-3 win; May 23, nine innings, nine hits, four earned runs, 10 K's, a 10-5 win.

He gave up five runs in six innings in his last start — encouraging for most Diablo hurlers of the past two years, a setback for Brown.

With a 5-4 record and 3.48 ERA, Brown's stats are almost identical to Joel Crisler's record with the Diablos last June when Crisler was summoned to Salt Lake City.

Plainly put, what happened?

"I realized I couldn't just throw the ball by people in Class AA as you can in Class A," recalls the low-key, courteous, 25-year-old with a self-effacing

humor (he says his nickname is "Downtown" because "that's where the ball goes when I throw it.")

Not only did he add a change-up to his slider-fastball staples, he added a pitch, so to speak, to his mental repertoire. It's a curious thing. After each pitch, he walks off the mound into an invisible sound-proof room, hands on knees.

"I just blot out everything, the fans, the situation, just clear my head," the University of California-Davis product says. "I started it here last year when I was getting drilled. I always used to work too fast. It helps me slow down."

Brown does not break up his one-man consultation with ball slammed into glove, a sneer affixed on his lips, ala major league Al Hrabosky.

"It's not an act for the hitter," Brown emphasizes in rejecting any Hrabosky influence. "I've never seen anybody do it quite like this."

If Steve Brown's success continues, however, it's not likely to remain a trade secret.